

TAIGA FOREST

Russia's forests cover more than two-fifths of the country's territory. The taiga forest type extends across the Urals to cover much of Siberia. This type of forest is formed by small, widely spaced trees, with large areas of poorly drained marsh grasses.



Neenets man guiding a sledge and reindeer

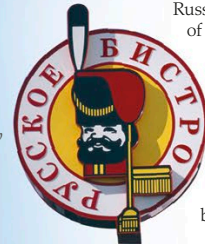


NATIVE PEOPLES

During the winter months, temperatures in Siberia regularly drop to below -45°F (-43°C). The native people who live here, such as the Neenets people of the Yamal Peninsula region, have adapted well to their environment and survive by herding reindeer, hunting, and fishing.

RUSSIAN LANGUAGE

Russian is the official language of the Russian Federation, but many of the 152 other nationalities inside the federation speak their own language as well. The Russian language uses the Cyrillic alphabet, which was devised by Greek missionaries.



OLD CUSTOMS

The communists tried to impose a Russian national culture on the native peoples of Siberia, but many of their customs survived in remote areas. Today, traditional costume, music, and dance are all flourishing throughout Siberia.



Russian dancer in traditional dress

Siberian tiger

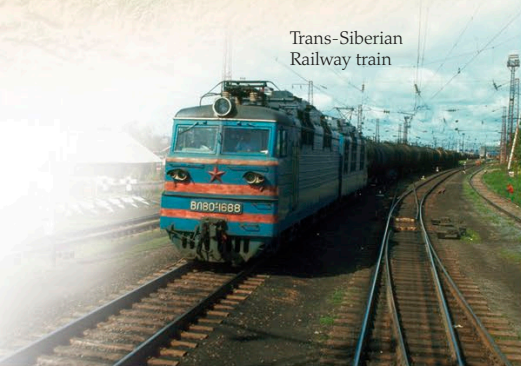


SIBERIAN WILDLIFE

Siberia is home to a huge range of wildlife, including the rare Siberian tiger (the biggest tiger in the world), wolves, reindeer, and black and brown bears. The Baikal seal—found only in Lake Baikal—is the world's only freshwater seal.



Trans-Siberian Railway train



TRANS-SIBERIAN RAILWAY

The longest railway in the world runs 5,772 miles (9,289 km) from Moscow's Yaroslavl Station in the west, across Siberia to the Pacific port of Vladivostok in the east. The railway was started in 1891 and took 14 years to finish. Trains take eight days to complete the journey and cross eight time zones.